

Express View on open-book examinations for Class IX: Not by rote

In a country where high school **marks** the **initiation** of a **frantic** race to **elite** institutions and **coveted** streams in higher education, the **decision** of the Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) to introduce **open-book assessments** for students of Class IX from 2026-27 **comes** as a **pedagogically** progressive move. **Shifting** the focus from **rote learning** to analytical thinking and real-world **application** **echoes** the goals of the National Education Policy 2020 and the National Curriculum Framework for School Education 2023. The present proposal aims to **integrate** it “as part of three pen-paper assessments per term”, covering core subjects like language, mathematics, science and social science. It is also **unlikely** to be made mandatory at the initial stage. With **thoughtful** design, open-book examinations (OBEs) can **democratise** assessment, **easing** the **anxiety** many students feel about **high-stakes** exams.

There are other **potential** gains. OBEs require creative imagination and a **multi-disciplinary** focus. At a time when artificial intelligence is **rewiring** views of **dissemination** of knowledge, skills and **employability**, OBEs can **nurture** independent thought, critical reading, and **ethical** information use — **competences** essential beyond classrooms and board rooms. By rewarding **comprehension** and **assimilation** over speed and memory, it also **stands to recast conventional** understanding of success and failure, especially for students who may not **excel** under time-bound, memory-intensive conditions.

However, the **execution** of recent educational reforms **strikes a note of** caution. CBSE’s previous **experiment** — the Open Text-Based Assessment introduced in 2014 — **was shelved** in 2017-18, **citing** a lack of “critical abilities” among students. **Rolling out** complex reforms like OBEs without first investing in teacher training and **equitable** access to resources **risks** repeating past **oversights**. **Analysis** of the result of the OBE **pilot study**, approved in 2023 for Classes IX to XII, **shows** “scores ranging from 12 per cent to 47 per cent, indicating challenges in effectively utilising resources and **grasping interdisciplinary** concepts”. This **points to** the **necessity** of further ground work to prepare students to **meet** the challenges of OBE, **a lack** of which in **under-resourced** schools, especially in rural areas, **may exacerbate inequalities**. The reform also arrives **amid** other changes, including the **restructuring** of **curricula**, **rationalisation** of text books and digital evaluation systems. There is a real danger that too many changes implemented too quickly may **dilute** impact and **overwhelm** both educators and students. OBEs hold great promise, and if done right, could make the education system more **compassionate**, holding **space** for different kinds of students. What comes next must be purposeful, with a **clear-eyed** understanding of past failures and current realities.

[Practice Exercise]

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where ‘red’ denotes ‘subject’ and ‘blue’ denotes ‘verb’.

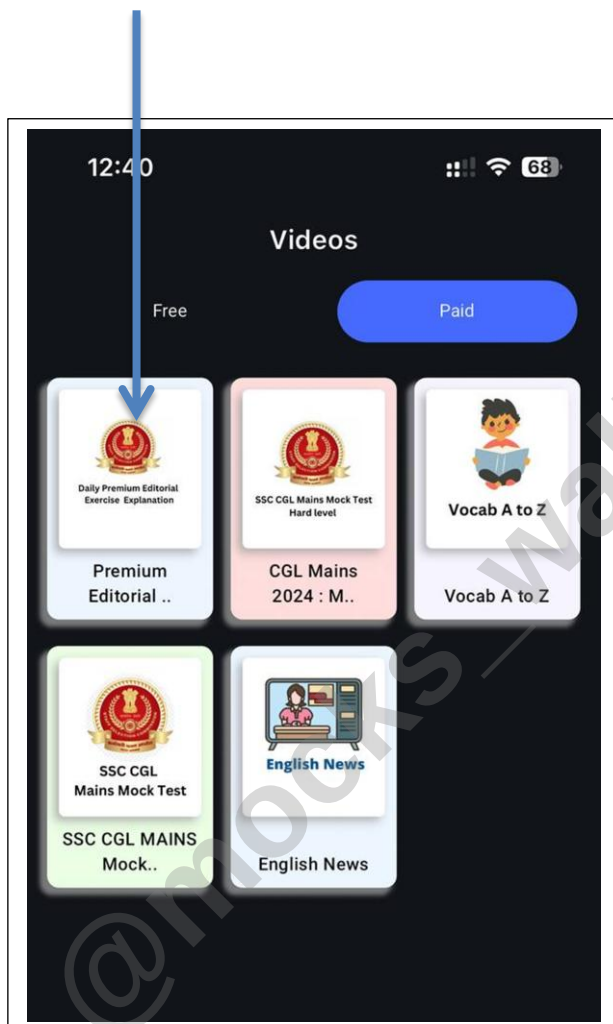
Vocabulary

1. **Learn by rote** (phrase) – memorise, repeat mechanically, learn without understanding
रटकर सीखना
2. **Mark** (verb) – indicate, signify, represent, denote, celebrate दर्शाना
3. **Initiation** (noun) – beginning, start, commencement, launch, inception शुरुआत / आरंभ
4. **Frantic** (adjective) – hurried, frenzied, agitated, panicked, hectic बेचैन / व्याकुल
5. **Elite** (adjective) – exclusive, select, superior, top-tier, high-class विशिष्ट
6. **Coveted** (adjective) – desired, sought-after, prized, wanted, longed-for अत्यधिक चाहा गया
7. **Open-book assessment** (noun) – exam allowing use of reference materials खुली किताब परीक्षा
8. **Pedagogically** (adverb) – educationally, academically, didactically, instructionally शैक्षणिक दृष्टि से
9. **Rote learning** (noun) – mechanical memorisation, repetition-based learning रटने पर आधारित शिक्षा
10. **Application** (noun) – use, implementation, employment, utilisation, practice प्रयोग
11. **Echo** (verb) – reflect, mirror, repeat, imitate, resonate दोहराना
12. **Integrate** (verb) – combine, merge, blend, incorporate, unify सम्मिलित करना
13. **Unlikely** (adjective) – improbable, doubtful, questionable, uncertain, implausible असंभावित
14. **Thoughtful** (adjective) – considerate, reflective, contemplative, mindful, careful विचारशील
15. **Democratise** (verb) – make accessible, equalise, liberalise, decentralise, popularise जनसुलभ बनाना
16. **Ease** (verb) – relieve, reduce, lessen, alleviate, mitigate कम करना
17. **Anxiety** (noun) – worry, concern, fear, apprehension, unease चिंता / घबराहट
18. **Potential** (adjective) – possible, latent, inherent, probable, prospective संभावित
19. **Multi-disciplinary** (adjective) – involving various fields, cross-disciplinary, integrative बहु-विषयक
20. **Rewire** (verb) – restructure, reorganise, reconfigure, reset, reprogram पुनर्गठित करना

21. **Dissemination** (noun) – distribution, spread, circulation, propagation, diffusion
प्रसार-प्रचार
22. **Employability** (noun) – job readiness, work capability, hireability, competence, qualification
रोज़गार-योग्यता
23. **Nurture** (verb) – cultivate, foster, encourage, promote, support
बढ़ावा देना
24. **Ethical** (adjective) – moral, principled, virtuous, honest, righteous
नैतिक
25. **Competence** (noun) – ability, skill, capability, proficiency, expertise
योग्यता / दक्षता
26. **Comprehension** (noun) – understanding, grasp, perception, interpretation, knowledge
समझ
27. **Assimilation** (noun) – absorption, integration, incorporation, adoption, adaptation
आत्मसात करना
28. **Stand** (to) (verb) – be likely to, be in a position to, have potential to
संभावना होना
29. **Recast** (verb) – reshape, reformulate, reframe, rework, remodel
फिर से बनाना / रूपांतरित करना
30. **Conventional** (adjective) – traditional, customary, orthodox, usual, established
पारंपरिक / परंपरागत
31. **Excel** (verb) – shine, surpass, outdo, be outstanding, perform well
श्रेष्ठ प्रदर्शन करना
32. **Execution** (noun) – implementation, performance, accomplishment, carrying out
क्रियान्वयन
33. **Strike a note of** (phrase) – express, convey, suggest
भाव प्रकट करना
34. **Shelve** (verb) – postpone, put aside, abandon, suspend, drop
टालना
35. **Cite** (verb) – mention, refer to, quote, allude to, name
हवाला देना
36. **Roll out** (phrasal verb) – launch, introduce, implement, commence
लागू करना / प्रारंभ करना
37. **Equitable** (adjective) – fair, just, impartial, unbiased, even-handed
न्यायसंगत / समान
38. **Oversight** (noun) – supervision, watchfulness, monitoring, negligence, lapse
निगरानी / चूक
39. **Pilot study** (noun) – trial, preliminary research, test run, experiment
प्रारंभिक अध्ययन
40. **Grasp** (verb) – understand, comprehend, perceive, realise, apprehend
समझना / पकड़ना

41. **Interdisciplinary** (adjective) – cross-subject, integrative, multi-field बहु-विषयक
42. **Point to** (phrasal verb) – indicate, show, suggest, highlight, signal संकेत करना / इशारा करना
43. **Necessity** (noun) – requirement, essential, need, prerequisite, obligation आवश्यकता
44. **Meet** (verb) – fulfil, satisfy, comply with, achieve पूरा करना
45. **Under-resourced** (adjective) – lacking resources, poorly equipped, deficient in facilities संसाधन-विहीन
46. **Exacerbate** (verb) – worsen, aggravate, intensify, heighten, compound बढ़ाना / बिगाड़ना
47. **Inequality** (noun) – disparity, imbalance, injustice, unfairness असमानता
48. **Amid** (preposition) – among, in the middle of, surrounded by, during के बीच
49. **Restructuring** (noun) – reorganisation, rearrangement, overhaul, reform पुनर्गठन
50. **Curricula** (noun) – syllabi, courses, study programs पाठ्यक्रम
51. **Rationalisation** (noun) – The process of making something more logical, efficient, or consistent.
52. **Dilute** (verb) – weaken, reduce, diminish, lessen, water down कमजोर करना
53. **Overwhelm** (verb) – overpower, overload, submerge, crush अभिभूत करना
54. **Compassionate** (adjective) – sympathetic, kind, humane, understanding दयालु / सहानुभूतिपूर्ण
55. **Space** (noun) – room, capacity, scope, freedom, opportunity गुंजाइश
56. **Clear-eyed** (adjective) – realistic, pragmatic, discerning, sensible, rational स्पष्ट दृष्टि वाला / व्यावहारिक

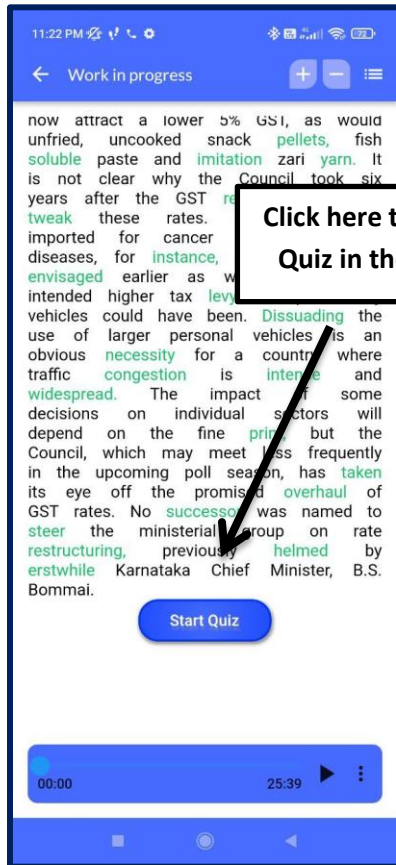
Video solution of Practice Exercise from this Editorial is exclusively available on App.



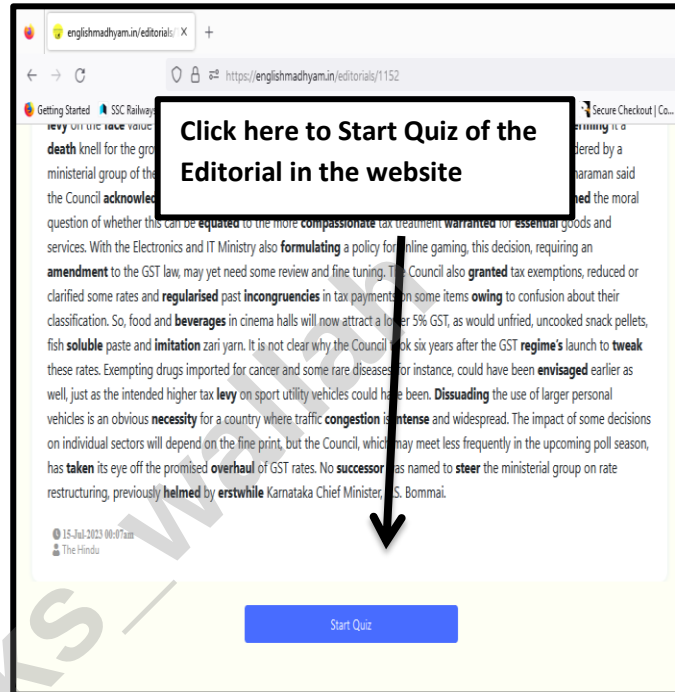
Summary of the Editorial

1. The CBSE will introduce open-book assessments (OBEs) for Class IX from 2026-27 as a progressive educational reform.
2. The aim is to shift focus from rote memorisation to analytical thinking and real-world application.
3. The move aligns with the National Education Policy 2020 and the National Curriculum Framework for School Education 2023.
4. OBEs will be part of three pen-paper assessments per term in core subjects like languages, mathematics, science, and social science.
5. Initially, participation in OBEs is unlikely to be mandatory.
6. Thoughtfully designed OBEs can democratise assessment and reduce anxiety associated with high-stakes exams.
7. They encourage creativity, multi-disciplinary learning, and independent thinking.
8. OBEs reward comprehension and assimilation over speed and memory, redefining traditional measures of success.
9. This reform could benefit students who struggle with time-bound, memory-heavy tests.
10. CBSE's earlier attempt, the Open Text-Based Assessment (2014), was discontinued in 2017-18 due to inadequate critical thinking skills among students.
11. The OBE pilot study in 2023 for Classes IX-XII showed low scores (12%–47%), indicating challenges in resource use and interdisciplinary understanding.
12. Successful implementation will require significant investment in teacher training and equitable resource access.
13. Without preparation, OBEs could widen educational inequality, especially in under-resourced rural schools.
14. The reform is being introduced alongside other major changes like curriculum restructuring, textbook rationalisation, and digital evaluation, raising concerns about overload.
15. To succeed, OBEs must be implemented purposefully, learning from past failures and considering current educational realities.

Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based



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